

ASSESSMENT 1 | BEFORE YOU BUILD

Sneha Raj | 24bcs10295

1. THE AMBIGUOUS SITUATION

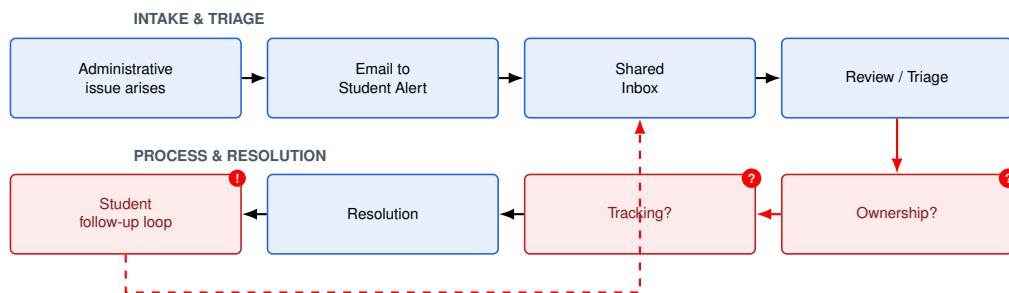
Students are swarming administrative offices across campus because their emails to **Student Alert** are going unanswered. They are stuck waiting on urgent mess clearances, fee disputes, and credit corrections, and when days go by without a response, they start chasing staff down in corridors or showing up at office desks unannounced. The admin team managing the shared inbox says they are buried under the backlog and constant walk-in interruptions. Now, leadership is demanding to know: “Why haven’t we just put an AI chatbot on the student dashboard to answer these queries automatically and make this support mess go away?”

THE ARGUMENT: Leadership asks for an AI chatbot → Investigation reveals requests enter a shared inbox without reliable ownership or end-to-end tracking → **First problem to solve: reliable request ownership and tracking** → Test a centralized request workflow, not AI → Measure follow-ups, resolution time, and staff workload → Decide next investment from evidence.

2. STAKEHOLDERS

Stakeholder	Role	Why They Matter	What We Need to Learn
Students	Experiencing the problem	Directly experience delays and resort to repeated follow-ups or office visits.	What happens after they submit a query? Where do they experience uncertainty?
Student Alert Admin Staff	Operating the workflow	Receive and manage incoming queries; experience the backlog and interruptions.	How are queries reviewed, prioritized, assigned, and tracked today? Where do they get stuck?
Finance, Mess & Academic/Credit Staff	Operating the workflow	Responsible for resolving specific categories of requests and handling handoffs.	How do requests reach them? What causes delays, rework, or unclear ownership?
Administrative Leadership	Accountable for outcome	Responsible for the overall student administrative experience and pushing for a solution.	What outcome are they trying to improve? How do they currently judge the problem?
IT / Dashboard Team	Enabling solution	Can provide the systems, data, and technical capabilities if a change is justified.	What existing systems and constraints would affect potential solutions?

3. CURRENT WORKFLOW & EVIDENCE



FACTS	UNKNOWNNS	BOTTLENECKS
- Requests enter the shared inbox. - Multiple staff have access. - No proper tracking from submission through resolution. - Students follow up or visit in person when responses are missing/unsatisfactory. - Staff redirect students to private emails when written trails are needed.	- How requests are triaged and ownership assigned. - Whether every request has a clear owner. - How requests are tracked after review. - Where requests most frequently get stuck. - Whether lack of tracking is the main cause of the observed delays.	Ownership assignment: No clear owner per request. End-to-end tracking: No reliable status from submission to resolution. Follow-up loop: Unresolved requests generate walk-ins and interruptions.

4. PAIN, EVIDENCE & BUSINESS IMPACT

Who	Pain	Evidence / What We Know
Students	Requests can remain unresolved, leading to repeated follow-ups or in-person visits.	Students follow up when they do not receive a response or when the response is unsatisfactory.
Admin Staff	Shared inbox requests compete with follow-ups and walk-in queries.	Admin staff report dealing with the inbox backlog and walk-in interruptions.
Administration	Limited visibility into what happens to a request after submission.	There is no proper tracking from request submission through resolution.

EVIDENCE GAPS TO VALIDATE:

- How many requests remain unresolved?
- How long do requests typically remain pending?
- What proportion require student follow-up?
- Where do requests most often get stuck?

BUSINESS IMPACT:

- Staff workload:** Repeated follow-ups and walk-ins add to administrative workload.
- Operational visibility:** Administration lacks end-to-end visibility into pending requests.
- Student admin:** Delays hold up important clearances, corrections, and decisions.

5. PROBLEM STATEMENT

“Student administrative requests enter the shared Student Alert inbox without reliable end-to-end tracking, making it difficult to know their status, ownership, and progress toward resolution.”

WHO	WHERE	WHY IT MATTERS
Students submitting administrative requests such as mess clearances, fee disputes, and credit corrections.	Across the Student Alert workflow, from the point a request is submitted until it is resolved.	Students repeatedly follow up/visit offices; staff handle interruptions alongside inbox load; administration lacks clear visibility.

SMART TARGET: Within 3 months of implementing the improved workflow, establish a measurable baseline and reduce the percentage of actionable Student Alert requests requiring student follow-up by a target determined from the baseline audit.

6. SUCCESS METRICS

Type	Metric	What It Measures / Ensures
PRIMARY KPI	% of actionable Student Alert requests resolved without student follow-up	Measures whether requests are being resolved without requiring the student to chase staff.
SUPPORTING	Median time: submission → resolution	Measures how quickly requests are completed.
SUPPORTING	% of requests assigned an owner within 1 business day	Measures whether requests are picked up promptly.
SUPPORTING	Student follow-up / walk-in rate	Measures how often unresolved requests create additional student interactions.
GUARDRAIL	Resolution quality / re-open rate	Ensures faster resolution does not come at the cost of incorrect or incomplete responses.
GUARDRAIL	Staff workload	Ensures the new process does not create excessive additional work for administrative staff.

Baseline: Establish through an audit of historical Student Alert requests.

7. MVP SCOPE

Core Hypothesis: If student administrative requests are submitted through a centralized system with clear ownership and end-to-end status tracking, then fewer students will need to follow up on their requests, and administrative staff will have better visibility into pending work.

✓ WHAT WE WILL BUILD	✗ EXPLICITLY OUT OF SCOPE
Centralized Request System (Student Dashboard) Student Side: - Single "Raise Request" entry point - Capture category, description, and documents - Provide request ID and visible status - Track: Submitted → Assigned → Pending → Resolved Admin Side: - Centralized dashboard for staff - View requests, assign owners, update statuses - Record a brief resolution note before closing	- AI chatbot or automated responses - Automatic resolution or decision-making - Replacing Finance, Mess, or Academic systems - AI-based prioritization or routing - Advanced analytics or predictive features - Other student-support channels outside the Student Alert workflow

8. VALIDATION & CONCLUSION

What Must Be Proven	How We Will Validate
1. Problem significance	Audit recent Student Alert requests to establish backlog size, resolution time, and frequency of follow-ups.
2. Genuine workflow gaps	Interview staff and relevant teams; trace requests from submission to resolution.
3. Centralized system works	Pilot proposed workflow with a limited set of real requests; compare follow-up rate, resolution time, and ownership vs. current process.
4. Avoids excessive staff burden	Measure staff effort during the pilot and collect feedback on the new workflow.
5. Solution level is appropriate	Determine whether a student-facing system is necessary, or if an internal tracking layer solves it with less change.

GO / NO-GO: Proceed with broader development only if evidence confirms that poor request tracking/ownership materially contributes to delays and the centralized workflow improves the primary KPI without materially increasing staff workload.

WHY THIS PROBLEM FIRST?

Leadership asked for an AI chatbot. But the evidence points to a workflow gap: requests lack reliable ownership and end-to-end tracking, causing student follow-ups and staff interruptions. Before building AI, we must validate whether a centralized request-tracking workflow fixes the real bottleneck. This is the right problem to solve first because it addresses the observed pain directly and tests the hypothesis before significant investment.